
New Gecko Parent Guide



Everything you need for a happy, confident
start together — from shopping lists to
first-week wisdom, the Sprout way.

Before Sprout Arrives

The welcome-home shopping list



The essentials

- ☐ 20-gallon long tank minimum for an adult
- ☐ Under-tank heater (not just an overhead lamp)
- ☐ Thermostat to control the heater
- ☐ Thermometer & hygrometer
- ☐ 3 hides — warm side, cool side & a humid hide
- ☐ Solid substrate (paper towel, tile, or reptile carpet)

The happy extras

- ☐ Calcium powder for dusting insects
- ☐ Shallow water dish
- ☐ Feeding tongs
- ☐ Climbing décor & background
- ☐ Digital probe thermometer for precise readings

Sprout's tip

Set up and run the tank for a couple of days before your gecko arrives, checking that the warm and cool sides both hold steady temperatures.



The First Week



Slow and gentle wins every heart

DAYS
1–2

Quiet settling

Let your gecko settle into the tank with no handling. Confirm temperatures are holding steady on both sides. Resist the urge to check on them constantly — frequent tank-peering can be more stressful than just letting the thermostat do its job.

DAYS
3–4

First meal

Offer the first meal once your gecko seems calm and is exploring — a stressed gecko often won't eat right away, and that's okay. If they refuse the first meal offered, that's normal — just try again in a day or two rather than forcing it.

DAYS
5–7

Brief handling

Begin very short, gentle handling sessions if your gecko seems settled. Never grab or hold by the tail. Keep first sessions under a minute — a calm, brief interaction builds trust faster than a long one.

WEEK
2+

Routine care

Settle into a feeding rhythm (daily for juveniles, every 2–3 days for adults) and find a reptile-experienced vet. Start a simple feeding log (date, what, how much eaten) — it makes it much easier to spot appetite changes later.



Feeding Basics

Happy tummies, healthy bodies



How much & how often

- 🐾 Insects dusted with calcium powder at most feedings
- 🐾 Portion size: about 5-8 appropriately sized insects per feeding for an adult (fewer, more frequent feedings for juveniles)
- 🐾 Juveniles: daily feedings. Adults: every 2–3 days
- 🐾 Prey size — no wider than the space between your gecko's eyes
- 🐾 Gut-load feeder insects 24-48 hours before offering them, using carrots, sweet potato, or dark leafy greens like collard or mustard greens
- 🐾 Common feeder insects: crickets, dubia roaches, and mealworms are all good staples
- 🐾 Remove uneaten live insects after feeding time

Never feed your gecko

- 🐾 Fireflies — even half of one can be fatal to a gecko
- 🐾 Wild-caught insects (pesticide risk)
- 🐾 Insects wider than your gecko's head (impaction/choking risk)

If something risky gets eaten

Call your vet or the ASPCA Animal Poison Control Center right away:

(888) 426-4435 — available 24/7



A Gecko-Safe Home

Curiosity-proofing 101



Safe greenery instead

- 🐾 Tank-safe decor: pothos, snake plant, or pilea, kept out of reach of the heat source (geckos don't eat plants, but keep any greenery purely decorative)

Around the house

- 🐾 Tank away from direct sun and drafts — temperature swings are dangerous
- 🐾 Never use loose sand-like substrate for young or new geckos — impaction risk
- 🐾 Confirm your vet actually treats reptiles before an emergency happens
- 🐾 Have a backup heat plan in mind in case of a power outage
- 🐾 Keep the tank lid secure — a gecko squeezing out is a real (if rare) risk



Cleaning & Care

A simple rhythm keeps everyone healthy



Every day

- 🐾 Spot clean — remove waste and any uneaten insects
- 🐾 Check and refresh the water dish

Every week

- 🐾 Change or wash paper towel/reptile carpet substrate
- 🐾 Wipe down the glass and any decor with a reptile-safe cleaner

Good to know

- 🐾 Full deep clean (empty the tank, disinfect surfaces, rinse thoroughly): monthly
- 🐾 Never use household cleaners with residue-heavy chemicals — even trace amounts are dangerous to reptiles
- 🐾 Replace humid hide moss/substrate as it dries out — usually every 1-2 weeks



Health & Vet Care

A little routine goes a long way



The usual schedule

- 🐾 A reptile-experienced vet visit within the first couple of weeks
- 🐾 Annual wellness check-ups for healthy adults
- 🐾 Ask about safe shedding support and metabolic bone disease prevention

Call the vet if you notice

- ♥ Sunken eyes or loose, wrinkled skin (dehydration)
- ♥ Not eating for over a week, or a thin/dark tail (fat store depleted)
- ♥ Stuck shed, especially around the toes or tail tip
- ♥ Open-mouth breathing, lethargy, or glass surfing (stress pacing at the glass)

My gecko's vet info

Clinic: _____

Phone: _____

Emergency clinic: _____

Phone: _____



Cool Gecko Facts

A little trivia to impress your friends



1

Leopard geckos have movable eyelids — most other gecko species don't, and lick their eyes clean instead.

2

They can voluntarily drop their tail as a defense (autotomy) and regrow a new one, though the replacement looks a bit different.

3

With good care, leopard geckos commonly live 15-20 years — far longer than most first-time owners expect.

4

They store extra fat reserves in their tail, which is why a healthy tail should look plump, not thin.

5

Unlike many climbing gecko species, leopard geckos don't have toe pads — they're ground-dwelling and can't climb smooth glass.

6

Selective breeding has produced over 100 different color and pattern varieties, called morphs.

7

Leopard geckos are crepuscular, meaning they're most active at dawn and dusk rather than fully nocturnal.

8

Geckos can vocalize — soft chirps or squeaks are sometimes used to communicate, especially between males.

9

Leopard geckos 'smell' with their tongue, flicking it to pick up scent particles and deliver them to a special organ (the Jacobson's organ) in the roof of their mouth.

10

A gecko's audible chirp or squeak is unusual for a reptile — most reptile species are essentially silent.

